

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Mid-Year — The Cohort at Its Lowest

The end of January and the first two weeks of February are, every year, the lowest morale stretch of senior year. The English teachers know this. The counselors know this. The principal, who has been at the school for twenty-six years, knows this. The kids do not know it yet. It is dark out at four-thirty. The sky has been gray for weeks. The college decisions have started rolling in but not all of them — most of the regular-decision results come in March, which means most seniors are stuck in a slow drip of did I get in yet, am I going to get in, which is one of the most exhausting psychological states a person can be in. The cohort, in mid-February, was tired.

Amara was tired. Even though she had her acceptance in hand. She was tired because the school was three months away and she was still emotionally close to her grandmother in a way that made the leaving feel — increasingly, as it got closer — like a real loss instead of an abstract one.

Marcus was tired. He had his state university acceptance. He had been waiting on one other school he had applied to with a long shot. The waiting was the wearing thing.

Sofia was tired. The biopsy scare was behind her, but the months of not sleeping had a long tail. She was, in February,

still recovering from December.

Priya was tired. She had not gotten her Boston school's decision yet. It would come in March. She was, every day, doing the work of not letting the Inner Critic colonize the waiting. The Critic was, this winter, louder than usual. The Critic had been telling Priya all month that the school was not going to accept her, and that she would have to settle for one of her safer schools, and that the settling would prove the Critic had been right about her all along.

Priya was, this winter, very tired.

Darius was tired. Pepper was gone. The house was quiet. Darius had not, in the four months since Pepper, gotten a new dog — his parents had asked, gently, in January, whether he wanted to start looking. He had

said not yet. He needed the empty space for a while.

Jordan was tired. His grandmother in Florida had called every Sunday since their January conversation and had asked, every Sunday, Jordan, are you really sure. Each Sunday call took something out of him. He was earning the trust. The earning was slow.

Maya was tired in a different way. She had had the conversation with her mother. The conversation had done its work. The post-conversation exhaustion was real — the way some conversations leave you, after, with a kind of emotional jet lag that lasts weeks.

Theo was tired. The asking, while it was working, was harder than the watching had been. The watching had been automatic. The asking required deliberate effort every time.

Kezia was tired. She had sent the letter. She had not heard back. She had told herself she did not need to hear back. She still — in some small place — checked the mail every day to see.

All ten of them — including Mia in Pittsburgh — were tired.

This is what Ms. Calloway came in to address on the first Friday of February.

She walked in. She put her bag down. She did not write anything on the board. She sat on the front of the long table where the cohort was assembled, her feet not quite touching the floor.

"Friends," she said. "It is February. You are tired."

The cohort looked at her.

"I know. I have done this with twelve senior classes before yours. February is the hardest month. The thing nobody warned you about, before senior year, is that the year is not actually peaking in May at graduation. The year peaks emotionally — for many of you — in March. From now until then, you are in the worst part of the year. The waiting. The decisions. The grayness. The realization that you are actually leaving, which has, until February, been theoretical."

She paused.

"I want to tell you a few things. Then I am going to give you a small task. Then I am going to let you go."

She looked at us.

"First. The tired you are feeling is real. It is not weakness. It is not laziness. It is what twelve years of building a life and then preparing to

leave it does to a body. The body is tired because the body knows what is coming. The body knows that, in a few months, the daily rhythm of seeing these nine other people every day is going to end. The body is doing some pre-grief work. That is what tired in February is. It is pre-grief." The cohort got very still.

"Second. The toolkit we have built across the years was built for exactly this stretch of the year. The slow breath. The

naming. The toolkit. The trusted adult. The friend. Use them. All of them. February is not the month to muscle through. February is the month to use the tools you have built. I would rather see you cry in my office four times this month than have you push through it alone. I would rather see you text Sofia at midnight than have you not sleep."

"Sofia, I am sorry to put you on the spot."

The cohort laughed. Sofia laughed.

"Third. February is also when the cohort matters most. You have spent twelve years building this group. The group is for February. The group is for the months when each of you is going to be tired in a different way, on a different day, and you can hold each other up. Not as a job. As a fact. Hold each other up."

"Fourth — and this is the small task — I want each of you to write down, on the paper I am about to hand out, the name of one person in this room you have not specifically thanked yet for something they have done for you in the last twelve years. One person. One specific thing. You are going to write the thank-you on the paper, and then you are going to hand the paper to that person at the end of class today."

"This is small. This is fast. This is going to feel awkward. Do it anyway."

She handed out the papers.

The cohort sat with their papers. The room was quieter than usual. Priya wrote her thank-you to Hannah. She wrote: Hannah. You caught my Inner Critic in a hallway in October. You called her by name. I have not thanked you. Thank you. — Priya.

Sofia wrote hers to Amara. She wrote: Amara. In December you sat across from me in the senior lounge and made me tell you about my mom. You did not let me lie about being fine.

You were the call-Amara when I needed one. Thank you. — Sofia.

Marcus wrote his to Theo. He wrote: Theo. You asked me about colleges in a hallway in November. We were ten minutes late to fourth period. I have been thinking about it ever since. Thank you for being the one who asked. — Marcus.

Amara wrote hers to Sofia. She wrote: Sof. In ninth grade, when I had the first really hard week at high school, you stood next to me at my locker for ten minutes and did not say anything and let me cry. I have not said thank you. Thank you. — Amara.

Maya wrote hers to Marcus. She wrote: Marcus. When I read my story out loud in third grade, you were the one who started the clap. I have not, in nine years, thanked you for that. Thank you. I think about it. — Maya. Jordan wrote his to Maya. He wrote: Maya. You read three of my short stories in junior year that I had not shown anyone. You did not laugh. You did not flinch. You said one thing that I have written down somewhere. You said "Jordan, you are doing the thing you do well." Thank you. — Jordan.

Darius wrote his to Sofia. He wrote: Sof. You came over the day after Pepper died and you did not say anything that was supposed to make me feel better. You just sat in the kitchen with me. You knew. Thank you. — Darius.

Theo wrote his to Hannah. He wrote, after a long pause: Hannah. We were not, for most of school, close. In photography class you said "Theo, you see things." I had been waiting to hear that for eighteen years. Thank you. — Theo. (Hannah Park was not in the cohort, but she was the person Theo wanted to thank, and Ms. Calloway, when she had given the assignment, had not strictly limited it to the cohort. Theo handed the note to Hannah Park later that afternoon, in

photography class. She read it. She did not say anything. She put it in her notebook and looked at him with a face that meant I see you. Theo would carry that face with him for the rest of his life.)

Kezia wrote hers to Marcus. She wrote: Marcus. When we were in seventh grade, you sat with me at lunch on a day when nobody else did, and you did not ask why I was sitting alone. You just sat. You do not even probably remember. I do. Thank you. — Kezia.

Mia, in Pittsburgh, did not get to do the assignment in class. But Sofia, who had been texting Mia about February exhaustion all week, texted Mia the assignment that afternoon. Mia did it. Mia wrote a thank-you to Sofia. Sof. You have been writing me letters since I moved

away nine years ago. You are the longest friendship I have ever had. You did the work of being my friend from far away when most kids would have let it lapse. Thank you. — Mi.

Sofia read Mia's text that evening.

Sofia cried, at home, alone, in her room.

Sofia, having recovered from December, cried in February in a much smaller, much sweeter way.

The cohort, that day, exchanged ten thank-you notes.

Each of the kids carried, that night and for many nights after, the thank-you they had received. The thank-you was — and Ms. Calloway had known this in advance, which is why she had assigned it — a kind of evidence. Evidence that the twelve years had been worth something. Evidence that they had, in fact, been kind to each other in specific ways across specific moments. Evidence that the small things they had done had been noticed.

February, in the cohort, got a little less tired after that day. The tiredness was still there. The grayness was still there. The

waiting was still there. But the cohort had — for one afternoon, on the first Friday of February — given each other proof that the twelve years had counted. This is what Ms. Calloway did, every February, for thirteen years. This is one of the reasons the cohort, when they think about Ms. Calloway in twenty years, will not remember any specific lesson. They will remember the feeling of the room. They will remember being seen. They will remember the assignment in February that turned out to be the small thing that got them through.

Ms. Calloway, who has been doing this for thirty years, knows what she is doing.

The cohort, who has been receiving it for twelve years, is starting to know what they have been receiving.

This is Part Two.

Part Two ends in the second week of February with ten kids who are tired but slightly less so.

Part Three starts in March.

Part Three is about forgiving — and not forgiving — the people who shaped them.

It is going to be the hardest part of the book.

It is also going to be the part where the cohort — and the readers — most fully figure out what they are bringing into the rest of their lives. — J.A.R., in the back of the room, watching (Just kidding. J.A.R. is not in the room. The narrator is gone. But the narrator, for one moment in the last sentence of Part Two, allowed himself a small visible re-emergence to say: yes. The cohort is doing the work. The architecture is holding.)

(Now back to the kids.)